

COLLEGE WRESTLING

Big brothers going strong

Dan Mitcheff, Lance Palmer qualify for national meet

Shaun Bennett
The Chronicle-Telegram

As their younger brothers were climbing onto the podiums in Columbus two weeks ago, Kent State's Dan Mitcheff and Ohio State's Lance Palmer were earning their way into the NCAA wrestling championships in Detroit today through Saturday.

Mitcheff, who won a state championship with Elyria in 2005, finished runner-up at 133 pounds in the Mid-American Conference Tournament. Palmer, who is from Columbia Station and won four state



Lance Palmer

titles at St. Edward, finished third at 149 pounds in the Big Ten Tournament. "I'm qualified to wrestle at the nationals because I got the wild card (selection)," Mitcheff said. "That was one of my goals for this season."

While Mitcheff was in Buffalo at the MAC tourney and Palmer was in East Lansing, Mich., for the Big Ten, Elyria High's Steve Mitcheff and St. Edward's Collin Palmer were at Ohio State's Value City Arena taking part in the state tournament.

"(Lance) coached me for the first two matches, then he had to leave after the quarterfinals," said Collin, who went on to win his second Division I state title. "He's real excited

about making it to nationals. He's ready to go."

All four of the wrestlers have high school state championships under their belts. Dan Mitcheff won his state title as a senior, while Steve won as a sophomore last season. Lance was the 15th wrestler to win four state titles, and Collin, who will be a junior next year, is halfway to matching his brother.

"(The MAC Tournament) was definitely more important (than the state high school tournament) because you either had to win it or be picked as a wild card to go to nationals," said Dan. "It's tough because a lot of the guys you wrestle are guys you've wrestled before and they know your style."

Dan Mitcheff lost 3-2 to Buffalo's Mark Budd in the championship. He was given a wild-card exemption to the national

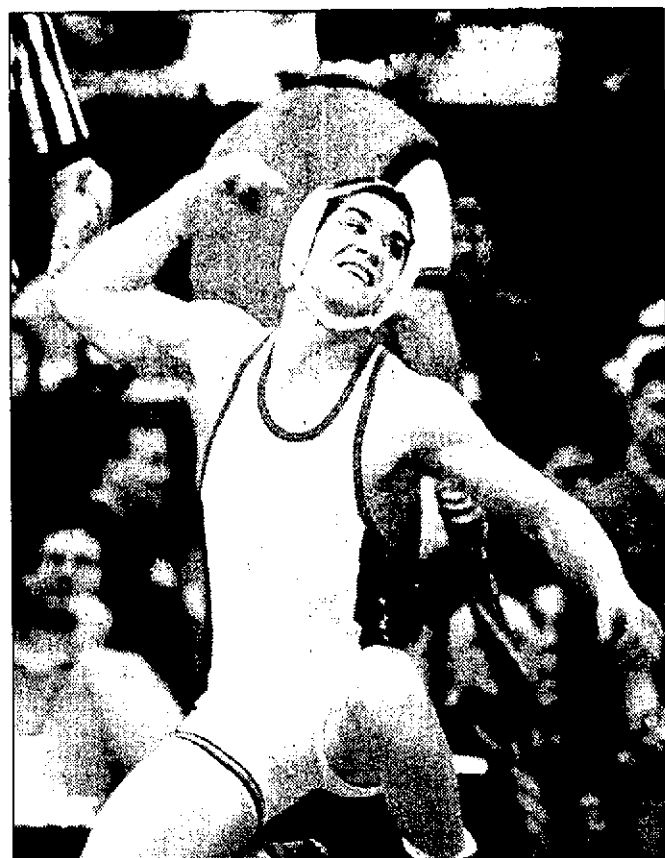
tournament by the MAC coaches.

"I lost to the Buffalo guy earlier in the year and I knew he was going to be my biggest competition at the MAC," said Dan. "Unfortunately, I didn't beat him. But I did enough that the coaches respected my ability and gave me a wild card."

While Mitcheff says he has no expectations — "I'm going to go out there with no worries and just wrestle hard," he said — Lance Palmer is ranked No. 16 in the nation at his weight and wants to finish in the top eight.

"He definitely wants to be an All-American this year," Collin said. "I think he can do it because he's such a hard worker and he puts the time in when it comes to training and practicing."

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CHRONICLE FILE

Dan Mitcheff, shown winning a state title for Elyria in 2005, will be looking for an NCAA title starting today in Detroit.



JASON MILLER / CHRONICLE

Olmsted Falls gets in a final practice Wednesday in preparation for tonight's regional semifinal vs. Kenmore in Canton.

FALLS

From C1

Kenmore has two 6-foot-8 players. Sinisa Srbijan, a senior center, averages about five points and seven rebounds a game, but came up big against SVSM with 10 points, 11 rebounds and three blocked shots. The other 6-8 Cardinal is sixth man Antoine Norris.

Miller, who averages 11 points a game to go with his dozen rebounds, is a 6-5 senior. Donovan Jackson, another senior starter, is 6-4.

The best player on the team might be the one whose head is closest to the floor: Marcus Golden, a 5-7 junior point guard, averages 19.5 points and five rebounds a game. Golden had 13 points in the district title game and was the guy who broke the SVSM full-court press.

Freeman, the fourth-year Kenmore coach, believes Golden will need to do as well, or better, if the Cards are to upset the eighth-ranked Bulldogs.

"We have to beat their press," Freeman said when asked what the key to the game will be. "Size is a big advantage for us. It's been a big advantage all year. We just have to keep up with their speed."

"If we can get them going up and down the floor, it will be to our advantage," Donahue said. "Our guys are a little faster than theirs."

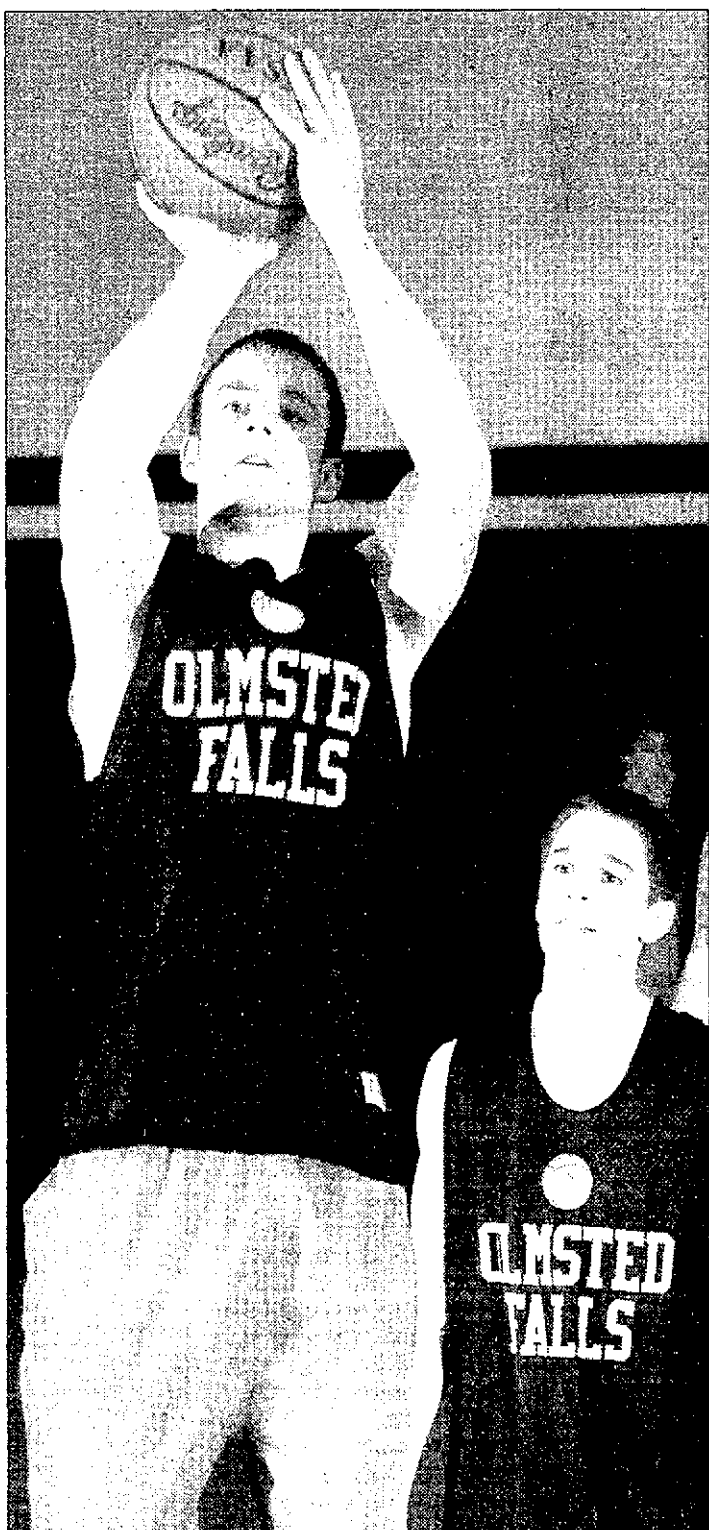
The trio of Tyler Sparks, Dave Pellerite and Pat Pellerite has led Olmsted Falls all year. The three, all 6-4, combine for more than 50 points per game. Sparks, also an All-Ohio quarterback, averages 11 rebounds and five assists a game.

Freeman added that the events of the district tournament should make the Cardinals' underdog status irrelevant.

"For us to get over Buchtel was a huge mental hurdle," he said. "We haven't been able to deal with Buchtel for years. That was a big confidence builder going into the St. Vincent-St. Mary game."

"We hit a bit of a bump in the road near the end of the regular season, but the kids have played their best ball of the year in the tournament. They have felt the urgency, I guess. They don't want to stop."

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JASON MILLER / CHRONICLE

Tyler Sparks, district player of the year, practices shooting Wednesday. The Bulldogs will likely need a big game from Sparks to help offset the height advantage of Kenmore.

TONIGHT

WHO: No. 8 Olmsted Falls Bulldogs (21-2) vs. unranked Kenmore Cardinals (16-6)

WHAT: Division II regional semifinal

WHEN: 7 o'clock

WHERE: Canton Fieldhouse, 1815 Harrison Avenue NW

AT STAKE: A berth in Saturday's regional championship game at Savage Hall in Toledo against either No. 9 Van Wert or No. 10 Upper Sandusky.

TICKETS: \$8 at the gate, \$6 pre-game sales at participating schools only

INFORMATION: Dan Brooks, tournament manager, (330) 454-4736

DIRECTIONS: Interstate 77 south to the Fulton Road exit in Canton. At the bottom of the exit ramp, do not turn onto Fulton Road, but go straight through the intersection onto Blake Avenue. Blake deadends in the Canton Fieldhouse parking lots. The fieldhouse will be on your left.

RADIO: WOEL 930-AM

Probable starting lineups

- Kenmore: Marcus Golden, 5-7, junior; Donovan Jackson, 6-4, senior; Joe Miller, 6-5, senior; LaQuon Smith, 6-5, sophomore; Sinisa Srbijan, 6-8, senior.
- Olmsted Falls: Dave Pellerite, 6-4, senior; Pat Pellerite, 6-4, junior; Alex Sedlay, 6-2, senior; Tyler Sparks, 6-4, senior; Mike Stallard, 5-8, senior.

Notable

- Olmsted Falls won the Southwestern Conference championship for the 11th time in the past 12 seasons with a 13-1 conference record.
- The only losses the Bulldogs suffered this season were to St. Ignatius, 62-58 in a non-conference game, and North Olmsted, 72-71 in an SWC game. St. Ignatius and North Olmsted are Division I.
- Olmsted Falls High School is two boys under the cutoff to be in Division I.
- The Bulldogs were Division I when they last won a district championship (2004). OFHS has been Division II for the past two seasons.
- The winner tonight in Canton has a chance to play against Jon Diebler, the career scoring leader in Ohio high school boys basketball history. Diebler, a 6-7 Ohio State signee, leads his Upper Sandusky team with an average of 42.4 points, 13 rebounds and seven assists a game. US plays Van Wert at Toledo today.
- The Cardinals came in third place in the Akron City Series with a 9-3 record.
- Prior to Saturday's upset of St. Vincent-St. Mary, Kenmore had not won the district title since 1974.
- Should the Cardinals beat Olmsted Falls, it will be the first time in Kenmore history that a boys basketball team has reached a regional championship game.
- Kenmore's 58 rebounds in the district championship game were a tournament record, beating the previous mark of 52. The Cardinals' 20-rebound advantage over the Irish was the widest margin ever in a district title game.
- SVSM made only six of 31 3-point field-goal attempts against Kenmore in the Barborton district championship.
- The Cardinals' tallest starter, Srbijan, is a native of Bosnia.

— Steve Byrne

NFL

Browns remain active

Robaire Smith agrees to deal; T. Smith cut

Scott Petrak
The Chronicle-Telegram

BEREA — One Smith in, one Smith out.

Oh, yeah, a McKinney was added, too.

The Browns agreed to a contract Wednesday with defensive lineman Robaire Smith, according to multiple reports and R. Smith confirmed by a source. ESPN.com reported the deal as four years for \$12 million, including a \$4 million signing bonus. The contract had not been signed as of late Wednesday night.

Smith, a seven-year veteran who's played for the Titans and Texans, will start at defensive end, replacing free agent Alvin McKinley.

The Browns terminated the contract of fullback Terrelle Smith, making him a free agent and finishing the removal of the starting backfield from 2006. The move follows the trade of running back Reuben Droughns to the New York Giants last week.

Former Miami Dolphins lineman Seth McKinney signed a one-year contract. He missed 2006 after surgery to repair a disc in his neck and will compete for a starting guard spot.

The Browns approached the offseason looking to improve both lines. They signed Eric Steinbach and re-signed Hank Fraley for the offense, before inking McKinney.

Robaire Smith was the first addition to the defensive line. The Browns also signed defensive tackle Shaun Smith to an offer sheet, but the Bengals have until Friday to match the offer. They aren't expected to match.

Robaire Smith (6-foot-4, 310 pounds) spent the first four years of his career with Tennessee, the next two with Houston and last year with Tennessee. In 96 games, he has 246 tackles and 15.5 sacks.

He played 3-4 end for the Texans in 2005, totaling 68 tackles and 1.5 sacks. He had 44 tackles and a half-sack in 2006.

Terrelle Smith joined the Browns in 2004 and appeared in all 48 games, including 32 starts. He started eight games in 2006 and had a year remaining on his contract. It was worth \$1 million.

Smith, a seven-year veteran, became expendable when the Browns drafted Lawrence Vickers last year in the sixth round. Vickers is more athletic.

McKinney (6-3, 310) played 61 games, including 34 starts, in five seasons with Miami. The Browns say he can play guard and center, but only three of his starts have come at guard.

McKinney, 27, started the first 13 games at center in 2005, as the Dolphins allowed just 26 sacks, the fourth-lowest total in the league. He missed the final three games after injuring his lower leg and had surgery to stabilize a joint.

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